

 Add icon Add cover

PIR - Issues with external recruitment page on the M&S career site impacting external candidates

M&S Digital&Tech *Post Incident Review*



Incident/ Problem Reference: INC90622655/PBI71510

Incident Date: 22/02/2025

PIR Date: 03/03/2025

Author: Gokula Krishnan

Attendees: Perminder Suri, Mudassar Kazmi, Sujay Bhowmick, Biplab Roy, Bhagyashree Borade, Saloni Chowdhury, Naveen Ernest, Gokula Krishnan

Technical Owner: Alex Fergus

PIR Reviewer: Kirsten Walker

1. Incident Summary :

Following the Oracle 25A quarterly patching, issues were observed whilst accessing the M&S external career page within the career site between 08:00 and 13:10, preventing external applicants from applying jobs. The initial root cause was attributed to a URL structural change resulting from the patching. Services were restored after a fix was deployed by Vendor Thirty-three. Root cause investigations underway with Oracle.

2. Incident Chronology :

21/02:

21:00 Oracle quarterly patching 25A was completed

22/02:

08:00 Planned sanity testing after the oracle quarterly patching was started

08:28 Identified that the External Job application page is not loading in the M&S Careers site, however, no impact to internal job pages

08:30 Case raised with vendor Oracle

08:50 Case was upgraded to Sev1

09:00 Additional details were asked

10:05 Vendor Thirty three, new jobs posting platform for jobs is being engaged

10:18 Trying to reach Thirty three account manager with no luck

10:40 Managed to get the Thirty three contact

11:02 Vendor Thirty three updated that the Oracle URL has changed

11:05 Call has been initiated with vendor Oracle to get this fixed

11:10 Vendor Thirty three joined the call and explained on the URL change

11:12 It was agreed with Thirty three to provide a tactical fix of the URL change and to be done by 1400

11:15 Oracle informed that there were no reports of such issues to them

11:30 Oracle updated that they will update us further on the issue by 13:00

12:24 Vendor oracle has raised BUG # 37625180 to investigate with their development team

12:40 Vendor Thirty three has applied the tactical fix.

12:45 Validations are in progress.

13:10 All required end to end validations are completed and confirmed that the external job application flow is working as expected.

3. Incident Resolution

Services were restored by vendor Thirty Three by amending the URL (changed as part of Oracle quarterly patch) to establish the connection to external career page through Thirty three connection.

4. Root Cause

The root cause is attributed to a URL structural change resulting from the Oracle quarterly patching.

Context:

The M&S Career website, hosted on the Oracle SaaS platform and the new jobs are posted in the site through the connection hosted by vendor Thirty Three. As part of the Oracle 25A patch, a URL structure change introduced by Oracle which resulted in issues while redirecting to the Thirty Three connection. Since, no customizations were made to the Oracle product, the product team overlooked the relevant release notes. The issue was missed during testing as the lower environment lacked this third-party connection. To address this, an exercise will be conducted to identify missing third-party connections, and a risk will be raised until the issue is resolved

5. Findings

5.1. Observability –

During the sanity testing done at 8 AM, the product team identified that external recruitment page was not loading, however all other sections of the career page were working as expected. We have agreed with the product team to do the post implementation checks after the implementation and involve the required vendors before it impacts the business.

5.2. Technical Challenges -

The existing SIT environment doesn't have Thirty three connections to test all the features across the M&S career website, therefore, testing was ineffective. As part of post incident analysis, it was identified that multiple other third party connections are unavailable in the SIT environment. Hence, it has been advised to raise a risk to highlight the testing efficiencies due to the difference in configuration between the production and SIT environment.

5.3. MIM involvement & impact assessment -

MIM was involved by the Service Lead, when they identified that the external applicants page was not loading, potentially creating a reputational impact.

There is an existing impact performance indicator, which helps in identifying the number of external job applications received over a period.

5.4. Incident handling/ stakeholder management –

Business and Tech colleagues were kept informed via Business communication and incident channels.

5.5. Business Communication –

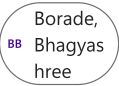
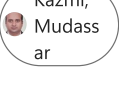
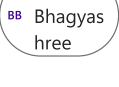
Although the business communications were sent in a timely manner, there were concerns raised about the clarity of the impact and progress updates, therefore we had a connect with all Service Leads to improve communication by specifying the direct business impact with business centric language for the stakeholders. An action was agreed to revisit the Distribution List's for the HR portfolio to use for the future communication.

5.6. Supplier Engagement –

Once the issue was identified, a high-priority case was raised with the vendor, Oracle. The product team got on a call with Oracle, who stated that they hadn't received similar incidents from other customers and assigned the case to their development. The Oracle Development team updated that the team is looking at possible ways to address this redirection via code and a fix is needed to address this redirection for old URL pattern. However, as we are currently unblocked the issue and the right thing is to use the new URL pattern, the Development team will possibly not backport this change, once they identify the best way to fix this.

Initially, there were challenges in involving the vendor ThirtyThree in the call. Since it was a Saturday, the product teams were unable to reach the right contact. Hence, it has been agreed to document all the 24/7 support contacts of all the 3rd party vendors including the vendors managed by M&S.

Mitigation Actions:

	Action	Owner	Due date	Remarks/ Updates	Action Category
1	Revisit the post checks procedures/timings to verify the features after a patching activity to ensure enough buffer time for the product teams to resolve an issue to avoid business impact	 Borade, Bhagyashree	Fri, Mar 1...	Patch was released by 21:00, however the sanity testing was performed by 08:00 next day only. Therefore, we have agreed to perform the post implementation checks after an activity by securing relevant access to test the functionality to allow enough time for triage if an issue occurs.	Problem Avoidance
2	Raise a risk to highlight the testing inefficiencies, due to the difference in configuration between the production and SIT environment across all the third party connections	 Kazmi, Mudassar	Fri, Mar 1...	SIT environment didn't have the third party connections (thirty three), due to which the issue was not identified in the testing phase.	Problem Identification & Alerting
3	Record the 24/7 support contacts across all the 3rd party vendors including the M&S managed vendors	 Kazmi, Mudassar	Fri, Mar 1...	Initially, there were challenges in involving the vendor ThirtyThree in the call. Since it was a Saturday, the product teams were unable to reach the right contact.	Supplier engagement
4	Review the DL's for the communication, if required separate DLs to be created with respect to impacted modules.	 Kazmi, Mudassar	Fri, Mar 1...	Currently there are no separate DL's for individual HR modules and comms were sent to individual email addresses during the issue. Service lead will be collating the individual details to be incorporated into a DL for future comms.	Business & Tech Comms
5	Review the release notes thoroughly and to involve vendor for any clarifications before the deployment	 Borade, Bhagyashree	Fri, Mar 1...	As part of the Oracle 25A patch, a URL structure change introduced by Oracle which resulted in issues while redirecting to the Thirty Three connection. Since, no customizations were made to the Oracle product, the product team overlooked the relevant release notes	Problem Avoidance

Please refer to  Major_ Significant and Key Incident Tracker 16th O... for progress updates on Mitigations.